

o r i o l e



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o r i o l e

WELCOME TEA

Warm chrysanthemum tea at the gate

STATION I - AT THE BAR

DRINK I

Black tea, yuzu spirit, vert jus

TRIO OF AMUSE BOUCHES

KING CRAB & UNI

Poached Norwegian king crab, Santa Barbara uni, Koshihikari rice, fresh shiso leaf, and bachelor button blossom

CARABINEROS

Grilled carabinero shrimp from Spain, sauce américaine, saffron aioli, sourdough sauce, shiso powder, and bachelor button blossom

HIRAMASA

Sake-cured hiramasa, radish, shio kombu, black lime togarashi, and concord grape ponzu

STATION II - AT THE KITCHEN

DRINK II

Rosé fennel vert jus, two teas of Saigon cinnamon tea and spicy chamomile tea

FOIE GRAS

Hudson Valley foie gras pâté on a brioche, tapioca pearl, pink peppercorn, gastrique, huckleberry, anise hyssop, and gold dust

STATION III - AT THE DINING ROOM

SPINY LOBSTER

Lobster from California seared with aromatic coconut milk infused with Thai chili, galangal, Makrut lime leaves, and lemongrass
Tapioca pearl and honeydew melon

LION'S MANE

Dried matsutake, egg custard, shaved raw Lion's Mane mushroom, black truffle,
poached foie gras, tarragon, and ginger chicken jus

SABLEFISH

Sablefish cured with shio koji, served with emulsified amazake sauce, golden Kaluga caviar, watercress purée, and fennel
Served with a smoked sablefish belly and potato tempura topped with crème fraîche and smoked white fish roe,
and a Parker House roll with koji-cultured butter with Hawaiian black sea salt

CAPELLINI

Caraway capellini pasta with Parmigiano Reggiano cheese, chives, beurre monté sauce with yeast
Burgundian black truffle, and puffed winter wheat berry

MIYAZAKI WAGYU

A5 Miyazaki wagyu grilled on charcoal, gem lettuce, pickled Hakurei turnip, Hakurei turnip sauce, Hakurei turnip powder,
fermented honey seasoned beef reduction, and freshly ground Japanese wasabi
Served with beef bouillon infused with shiso

APPLE

Components of apple, milk, and Oolong tea, champagne Long Kou Tea jelly, milk sorbet, and clarified apple broth

SOUFFLÉ

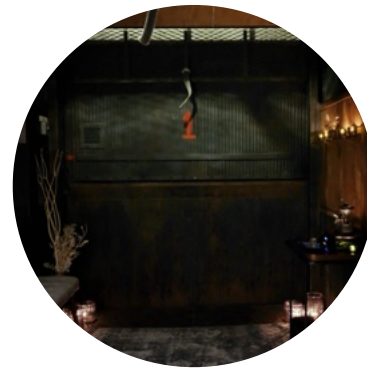
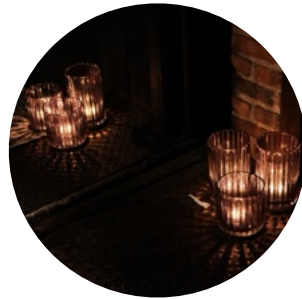
Soufflé of toasted sesame and lemon zest, fondue of Délice de Bourgogne cheese

CARROT BAUMKUCHEN

Carrot baumkuchen cake with chewy carrot, fenugreek, triangle barley ice cream coated with dulce chocolate and toasted white chocolate,
salted and dehydrated carrot shave, fresh lemon balm herb, and gastrique of balsamic vinegar

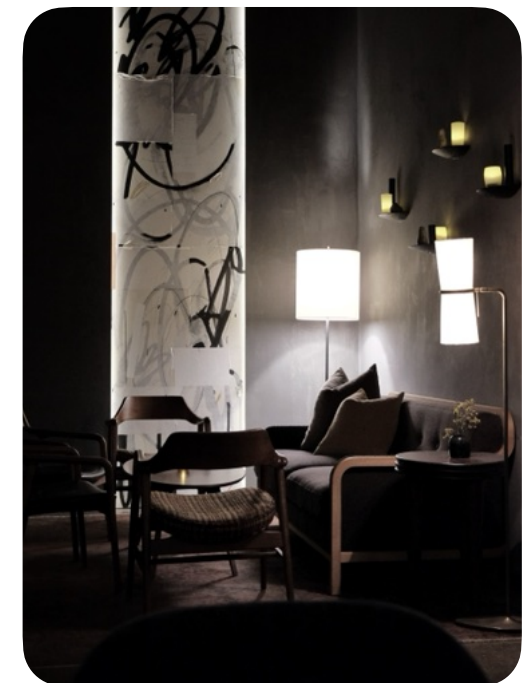
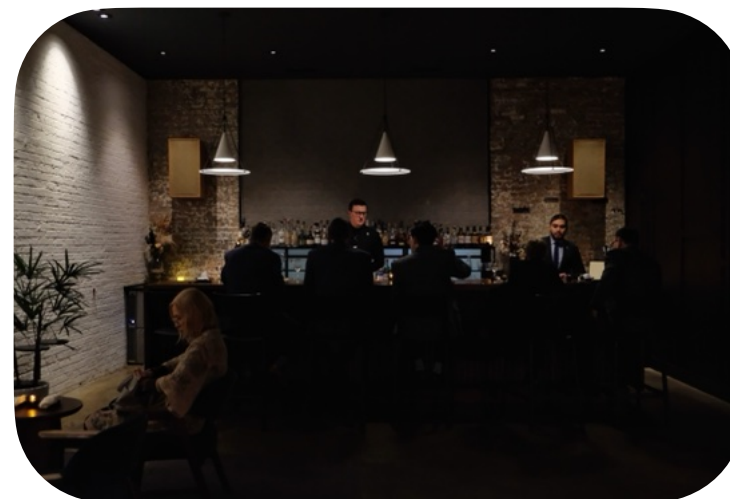
MIGNARDISE

Kohakutou flavored with kumquat and Japanese Oolong jasmine tea
Bonbon with miso, cassis pâte de fruit, coated in dulce chocolate
Bonbon with coconut, yuzu, dark chocolate, and herbs



Hidden behind a secret garden at the corner of the Walnut Street, I find the entrance to the legendary Oriole. Crossing the threshold, I enter a cozy cabin meticulously disguised with campfire-like candles, a comfortable sofa, and a ratio-coffee machine. Upon checking in at the front desk, I am soon offered a cup of warm chrysanthemum tea, which immediately drives away the coldness typical of the season in Chicago.

As I am immersed in the aroma of the chrysanthemum tea, the clock inadvertently strikes five o'clock. The heavy garage gate cracks open, I am then ushered into an expansive space with a sudden shift to a vibrant and energetic atmosphere. At the foyer of the restaurant is a bar area where the space is divided into several sections that perfectly fit various groups of guests. As soon as I comfort myself at the bar table, warm tower and welcome drink arrive to soothe me even more. Soon, I am enjoying a trio of welcome bites here while gazing at the busy kitchen next to the foyer.





Gushing a gentle effervescence, the non-alcoholic welcome drink quickly revives my palate with its sophisticated refreshingness and elegant mellow sweetness that are achieved through the combination of black tea, yuzu spirit, and vert jus. Without undue delay, the trio of amuse bouches arrive at the table. The first of the three is presented in the familiar gunkan-sushi shape. Inspired by traditional Japanese cuisine, the bite-sized dish consists of a koshihikari rice base wrapped in a crispy nori chip, topped with a duo of poached Norwegian king crab and Santa Barbara uni, and garnished with some fresh shiso leaves and bachelor button blossoms. The untamed oceanic umami and heavenly sweetness of the duo of seafood leave a lasting impression, yet the crispy nori wrap is unfortunately excessively thick and overwhelming, detracting from the overall enjoyment of the dish.

With a quick detour to Spain, my mouth is now showered by the igniting vitality of Spanish cuisine. The second dish features a grilled Carabinero shrimp from Spain, brushed with a trio of sauces including sauce Américaine, saffron aioli, and sourdough sauce. The distinct and robust Carabinero is perfectly complemented by the fiery saffron aioli and the richness of sauce Américaine which owes its depth to cayenne pepper, tomato, and brandy. To further elevate the dish, a touch of shiso powder and some bachelor button blossoms are also introduced. Ensuing the Spanish prawn, I am brought back to Japan with a rose-shaped dish comprising sake-cured hiramasa, radish, shio kombu, black lime togarashi, and concord grape ponzu. While both the kombu and ponzu or the togarashi and radish seem to be common in Japanese cuisine, here they are presented in a new design. With the addition of grapes to the ponzu, all these Japanese elements are rejuvenated and reborn in a new dish.

After finishing the three amuse bouches, I am invited to join in the other two parties to the center of the open kitchen. With its high ceiling adorned with vinyl record covers of pop music, the expansive space speaks for itself, reflecting not only the youthful and innovative temperament of the Oriole team but also their ambition. We stand in front of the center island, sipping another glass of welcome drink while witnessing the creating of our next amuse bouche.

The complimentary drink is based on a rosé fennel vert jus, and then further accented with two types of tea, namely the Saigon cinnamon tea and the spicy chamomile tea. As we are engulfing in the aromatic drink and the vibrant music in the kitchen, the next foie gras brioche arrives in front of us. On top of the brioche rests a layer of Hudson Valley foie gras pâté, topped with some tapioca pearl, pink pepper, gastrique, huckleberry, anise hyssop, and finally finished with some luxurious gold dust. The traditional manner of enjoying the pâté is well-preserved by spreading the pâté on a piece of brioche and pairing it with sweet or tart accompaniments to balance its rich and creamy texture, which in this dish are the gastrique sauce and the huckleberry. Yet there is a modern touch of alternation to the dish as the chef introduces the tapioca pearl, pink pepper, and anise hyssop to the medley.





After a brief tour of the kitchen, where I indulged in a luxurious treat of foie gras, I am led into the main dining room, newly renovated and gleaming with elegance. Gone are the mundane rectangular tables, replaced by round tables that exude a sense of refined luxury, offering diners ample space to savor the culinary delights that await. Yet, amidst the opulence, the raw exposed brick walls remain untouched, preserving the place's precious sense of humbleness that echoes with the oriental touch found in their cuisine.

Seating by the table, I lose myself in the pristine beauty of the chrysanthemum resting on the table, its delicate petals beckoning me into a world of serene tranquility. Suddenly, my attention is drawn to a bowl that has arrived at the table, divulging the vibrant temperament of Thailand. Within it, I discover spiny lobster from California, seared to perfection with an aromatic blend of coconut milk infused with Thai chili, galangal, Makrut lime leaves, and lemongrass. Tapioca and honeydew melon join the medley, imbuing it with additional layers of texture and fruity aroma, creating a sublime fusion of flavors that tantalize my senses.



The exuberant Thai heat lingers on the palate as the next dish is presented, a symphony of earthy flavors and delicate textures. The luxurious bowl of chawanmushi, boasts a rare combination of ingredients that dances on my palate. Working in perfect unison, the dried matsutake, shaved raw Lion's Mane mushroom, and black truffle comes together to form more than just a simple superposition of luxurious ingredients. And yet, there's more to this medley. Poached foie gras, tarragon, and ginger chicken jus work in harmony to bring a creamy richness and a mild herbal spiciness to the dish, creating a sensory experience that is both ethereal and grounded.





Now, a sumptuous trinity of culinary feast appears before me, a visual symphony of flavors and textures. The star of the show, Sablefish, sits majestically at the center, flanked by a miniature tempura and a soft, pillowy Parker House roll.

Lounging in a frothy bubble bath of emulsified amazake sauce, the sablefish evokes a mysterious oriental fantasy. The flesh is further underscored by a scoop of golden Kaluga caviar, as well as a touch of watercress purée and fennel. The sablefish stands at the heart of the composition as a jewel in the crown of this epicurean display. Yet, it is the koji, with its magical touch, that truly forms the essence of the flavor profile. It emerges first as shio koji, a cultured blend of rice and salt, infusing the sablefish with a rich umami reminiscent of white miso and soy sauce. But the koji's true alchemy is revealed as it assumes the role of a key ingredient in the fermentation of amazake. Here, it envelops the tender sablefish flesh in a ephemeral foam of luscious mellow sweetness, complemented by a gentle acidity that ignites the senses.



The magic of koji endures, bestowing upon the butter a sophisticated depth that sets it apart from the regular salted butter. Further imbued by the Hawaiian black sea salt, the butter reveals a tender touch of pungency. As it melts onto the rich, fluffy milk bun, it becomes a mystery on its own, a tantalizing enigma that entices me for further exploration. On the other side of the trinity rests a finger morsel of smoked sablefish belly and potato tempura. This exquisite creation not only echoes the sablefish at the heart of the dish, but also summons the essence of Japanese cuisine with the expertly crafted tempura. Topped with crème fraîche and smoked white fish roe, the delicate melange of smoky richness and oceanic umami is marvelously revealed in this tiny bite.



As I bid farewell to the oriental palace of ocean, I venture into the Emilia Romagna region with a dish that fuses culinary traditions from multiple cultures. The harmony of Italian and Central European cuisine has been finely tuned with French flair to create a unique gastronomic experience that transcends borders. Laying at the center of the plate is the caraway capellini twirled into a gorgeous nest, a delicacy that weaves the caraway of central European cuisine into the fabric of Italian pasta, a mesmerizing sight that celebrates the fusion. The capellini is kissed by the intertwining wisps of feathery Burgundy black truffle and Parmigiano Reggiano that are both finely shredded through a zester. This melange then bathes in a fine bath of rich creamy beurre monté sauce with yeast, chives, and puffed winter wheat berry. A true masterpiece of culinary artistry, a dish seamlessly blends the aristocratic elegance of French cuisine, the refined yet untamed temperament of Italy, and the pristine and rustic charm of middle European traditions.



If the capellini embodies the soulful aria of the scene, the next wagyu course is the grandest and most majestic yet profoundly stirring and heartrending tutti passage of the opera. Never did I anticipate a mere cut of wagyu beef to be executed with such finesse, nor did I anticipate it to elicit such undercurrent of my inner criteria. At the center of the pristine yet exquisite oriental stoneware rests a slice of A5 Miyazaki wagyu beef grilled over charcoal. This ancient alchemy of cooking endows the beef with a gentle smoky essence unique in a zen way that is reminiscent of a waft of incense from a Japanese temple, akin to a ceremonial offering to honor the beauty and sacrifice of the animal. The precise control of temperature allows the marbled fat of the beef to melt just right, locking in all the umami while coating the surface with a glistening glaze glow like jewels in the night. And in harmonious union with the wagyu, a humble gem lettuce is charred with finesse, transformed by the gentle kiss of the flames into a masterpiece of verdant hue. The succulent juice nestled within the gem lettuce flows like a mountain spring, offered with solemnity at the sacred ceremony, cleansing the palate of the rich wagyu's unctuousness.



In duet with the gem lettuce, a triumvirate pays homage to the crisp and succulent Hakurei turnip. Hemispheres of pickled Hakurei, artfully arranged and adorned with their own purée and powder, crown the lettuce with an enchanting flourish. A delicate hint of spice in the turnips imparts a subtle oriental nuance to the already sublime wagyu beef. Further adding to this dish is a heavenly fermented honey seasoned beef reduction. A celestial addition so exquisite, that if not for its inclusion, one might question the very foundation of the cuisine. The fermented honey imparts a sophisticated mellowness to the sauce, while also infusing the jus with a hint of Scandinavian temperament. The crowning glory of the medley, however, is the exquisite fresh wasabi. Presented in a lacquer tray and freshly ground before my eyes, the show honors its otherworldly transcendence and purity. Its subtle nuances of refined spiciness and irresistibly refreshing aroma evoke the unbearable lightness of being, elevating the beef to an ethereal sainthood. With a gentle touch after the final act, a cup of beef bouillon infused with fresh shiso arrives. Its role, much like that of a cup of tea, is to cleanse the palate of the lingering unctuousness from the dish. Yet, it does so with a refined subtlety, preserving the delicate umami essence of the beef like a minimalist melody by John Cage, leaving behind a trail of enchantment that lingers long after the last bite has been savored.



As I depart from the realm of savory delights, I embark on a journey to the land of saccharine pleasures. The pastry chef invites us to relive her memories of Taiwan, where she first tasted the apple milk boba tea at Seven-Eleven, an experience that forever etched into her soul. With her artistic flair, she weaves together the essence of the brew using an intricate interplay of textures of apple, milk, and oolong tea. The ethereal Champagne Long Kou Tea from Hugo Tea is metamorphosed into delicate jelly, in duet with spheres of apple and milk Sorbet, all embraced in a luscious Clarified Apple Broth. While the jelly balls do evoke fond memories of the boba, their texture falls short of perfection, weighted down by an excess of gelatin that detracts from the delicately airy composition. Perhaps a refined spherification technique could resurrect the dessert's glory. Imagine miniature orbs of oolong nectar exploding in one's mouth, evoking the shape of the boba while sustaining the ephemeral lightness of the dish.



Continuing in the realm of desserts, the pastry chef conjures up a truly enchanting spectacle of soufflé and cheese. Paying homage to the French culinary tradition, she defies convention by interweaving the boundaries between the savory and sweet, creating a masterpiece of culinary innovation.

The Délice de Bourgogne cheese fondue cascades over the Soufflé of toasted sesame and lemon zest, weaving an enchanting spell of flavors that blend everything into one harmonious chorale. Though the only flaw is the overly salty fondue, perhaps an extra quenelle of Délice de Bourgogne would bring the composition to a new dimension, balancing the flavors with hints of sweetness and breezing in a touch of icy freshness.

Ensuing the indulgent French soufflé course, I am now transported to the majestic world of Germany, where a sublime Carrot Baumkuchen cake awaits. The complex components of this enchanting dessert include chewy carrot, aromatic fenugreek, salted and dehydrated carrot shavings, fresh lemon balm herb, and a gastrique of balsamic vinegar. Yet the star of the show is undoubtedly the triangle-shaped barley ice cream, enveloped in a velvety coat of dulce chocolate and toasted white chocolate, divulging a unique folk tone that underscores the composition of carrot. The ingenious chef masterfully blends elements from the savory world, such as the carrot and barley, and the piquant fenugreek, creating an intriguing flavor profile and achieving the perfect equilibrium of sweet and savory.

As the journey of multitudinous sweetness draws to a close, the petit fours appears on the table, evoking a symphony of flavors that seamlessly blend Japanese essence with French artistry. In a small tray rests a piece of Japanese Kohakutou candy, infused with the alluring aromas of kumquat and Japanese Oolong jasmine tea. Alongside this precious gem, I discover two pieces of exquisite bonbon, the first of which is enrobed in a delicate layer of dulce chocolate and filled with a sublime amalgam of miso and cassis pâte de fruit, sending waves of shock to my taste buds once more with a burst of savory-sweet fusion.

The second bonbon, another masterpiece of composition, brings together the tropical notes of coconut and yuzu, intertwining with the deep richness of dark chocolate and enlivened with the fragrance of fresh herbs. Together, these petit fours create a stunning finale to a journey of transcendent sweetness.





To further sublimite my evening repast, I give myself the liberty to indulge in two glasses of wine with a twinge of guilt, adding a touch of sinful pleasure to my culinary delight. A glass of Merkelbach 2021 Kinheimer Rosenberg Riesling Spätlese trocken is poured by my sommelier to escort my palate through the first half of my degustation journey. Its luminous freshness and elegant refinement seamlessly complement all the dishes, bestowing them with an extra hint of coolness. As I venture into the second half of my exploration, the champagne Grand Siècle Iteration N°25 unveils its heavenly aroma and unique fine craftsmanship. A mesmerizing blend of nine grand crus (Mesnil-sur-Oger, Cramant, Avize, Oger, Ambonna, Bouzy, Verzy, lours-sur-Marne, Mailly), three vintages (65% from 2008, 25% from 2007, and 10% from 2006), and two grape varieties of Chardonnay (40%) and Pinot Noir (60%) come together to create a magical experience. Its effervescence and exquisite flavors give my exploration an extra touch of magic, completing my degustation journey in a truly divine fashion.



My evening at this remarkable establishment unfolded flawlessly from the moment I crossed the threshold and was greeted with a warming cup of tea. Every detail of the service was executed with precision and finesse, leaving me in awe of the level of expertise and attentiveness of the staff. They effortlessly fielded my inquiries about the origins of each ingredient and the inspiration behind every creation, as if they were sharing cherished secrets with a dear friend. In fact, I was even gifted a pouch of the exquisite oolong tea to savor at my leisure after inquiring about its variety used in the apple milk tea dessert. Yet the hospitality extended beyond the dining room to the restroom, where every need had been thoughtfully anticipated. The elegant sink was adorned with luxurious Aesop hand soap and balm, while a selection of amenities including tampons, mouthwash, Oribe hair spray, and combs were provided for the ultimate comfort of guests.

As I say my farewell to the wine cellar, accompanied by my knowledgeable and most friendly waiter, I am left with the certainty that this is truly a once-in-a-lifetime experience that would stay with me forever. Oriole's commitment to providing the highest gastronomic and service standards is palpable in every detail, from the intricate decor to the attentive service, from the mesmerizing ambrosia to the fine selection of wine. Team Oriole ensures that every moment spent here is one of utmost indulgence.